



Alpine marmot

Marmota marmota

▷ SPARRING MALES

Alpine marmots will defend their territory against intruders and to maintain their dominance in the group.



Alpine marmots are large ground-dwelling members of the squirrel family. They are of a sturdier build than their tree-dwelling cousins, with powerful legs for digging into hard, rocky ground. Most of their digits have sharp claws except the thumb, which has a nail.

Burrowing down

Alpine marmots live at altitudes of 2,000–10,500 ft (600–3,200 m), but more commonly over 4,000 ft (1,200 m). They create extensive deep burrow systems in alpine meadows and high-altitude pastures above the tree line. In the summer months, they feed during the day on lush grasses and herbs, accumulating fat that will see them through the long winter hibernation. Alpine marmots spend as many as nine months in a year hibernating, sealed in their hay-lined burrows for insulation as well as safety. Adults and

older offspring cuddle up to younger animals to help maintain their body temperature, which drops as low as 41°F (5°C). While hibernating, alpine marmots breathe only one to two times each minute and their heartbeat drops to 28–38 beats per minute. They emerge in April when the mountains are still covered in snow. Dominant pairs mate soon after, and the young are born a month later.

Traditionally, alpine marmots were killed because their fat was thought to help with arthritis. They are still hunted for sport today.

▽ MOTHER AND YOUNG

Alpine marmots breed once a year, with litter sizes of one to seven. Mothers take on the main role of taking care of the young.

- ↔ 18–27 in (46–69 cm)
- ⚖ 5–14 lb (2.3–6.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grass, shrubs, herbs
- 🏠



C. Europe

